

At first the ploy succeeded, but after four hours' fighting, Union forces staged a successful counterattack and Gordon's men were driven back with heavy losses.

Major General George E. Pickett and Fitzhugh Lee, the senior officers of the Southern forces in the decisive encounter at Five Forks, were absent for much of the fighting, having been invited to a shad (fish) bake nearby by a fellow general.



Major General John B. Gordon

Gordon was one of Lee's most trusted lieutenants in the final stages of the war. He fought in many of the most important battles, from First Bull Run through Antietam and Gettysburg, and was wounded numerous times.